

# **Intermediate Woodturning**

Technique Handout, End Grain and Hollowing

Western Reserve Woodturners Guild

Instructor: Charles Ferguson

This handout goes with the class. Keep it on the bench. It is written plainly so you can read it with sawdust on your hands.

## **Why end grain checks**

Green wood loses moisture fastest through the end grain. When the ends dry faster than the middle, the wood splits. Sealing the end grain slows that loss so the blank dries more evenly and you keep your work. Seal a fresh blank the day you get it, not next week.

## Sealing steps

| Step | What to do                                       |
|------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Brush sealer on both end grain faces, two coats. |
| 2    | Let the first coat soak in before the second.    |
| 3    | Label the blank with species and date.           |
| 4    | Store off the concrete, on a rack with airflow.  |

You do not need fancy product. A consistent habit beats the best sealer used once in a while.

**Tool setup for hollowing**

| Tool                      | Use                                      |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Bowl gouge, half inch     | Truing and shaping the outside           |
| Bowl gouge, three eighths | Refining the rim and inside near the top |
| Hollowing tool            | Reaching the lower inside wall           |
| Calipers                  | Checking wall thickness as you go        |

Sharpen before you start. A dull gouge tears end grain and tempts you to push, and pushing is how walls blow out and how people get hurt.

## **Cutting the hollow**

Work from the center out and from the top down. Take light cuts. Ride the bevel, do not force the edge into the wood. Check the wall thickness often with calipers. It is far easier to take more off than to put it back. A clean finishing cut saves you an hour of sanding a torn surface.

## **Safety**

Tool rest close to the work and just below center. Face shield on. Sleeves rolled, no loose clothing near the lathe. Stop the lathe before you reach in to check anything. If the wood is fighting you, stop and reset the rest or resharpen rather than muscling it.

## **Practice at home**

Seal two blanks this week and start one small hollow form. Bring your questions and your problem pieces to the next class. We learn more from a wall that blew out than from one that went perfectly.

Charles Ferguson, intermediate class instructor.